S. FARZEEN ROSE, 22

Final-year law student

Lok Sabha constituency: Thiruvananthapuram

Top 3 demands: Stop spreading communalism, ensure equal justice, tax corporates more

What will influence her vote: Erosion of democracy, threats against federalism, India's global image

"I feel angry when justice is denied to the poor, pained when lawmakers disregard the Constitution"

Shashi Tharoor and BJP's Rajeev Chandrasekhar. Leaders like Pannyan, she says, should be in Parliament to give a voice to the poor. Farzeen wants to teach law, in the firm belief that legal awareness helps people to protect their own as well as the rights of others. Pointing to the arrest of Jesuit priest Stan Swamy, who died in jail, and Delhi University professor G.N. Saibaba under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, she says, "Delayed justice is not a comfort for those who challenge people in power." ■

- Jeemon Jacob

It was in Singapore during her graduation days that Gagana Ganesh hit upon her business idea. Over the next two and a half years, she did stints at software firm Zoho and edtech start-up Unacademy before setting up her venture, Grab Me, a packaged food brand which sells snacks in bite-sized packs. She now has a seven-member team and supplies to 120 supermarkets across Bengaluru. Gagana feels the top priority for the next government should be reducing unemployment. Among the solutions she suggests are setting up huge manufacturing units. "The next big priority would be to support start-ups better," she adds. While there are schemes mentioned on government websites like Startup India, there's very little information on how to avail these, says Gagana. "You want to avail a particular benefit and you reach out to the bank, but then they don't know about it. There's no one to help us avail these benefits." Citing the experience of fellow entrepreneurs, she says start-ups go through a "trial and error process to figure out things, which is very time-consuming". ■

Top 3 demands: Tackling rural unemployment, helping cope with layoffs, better support for start-ups

"The No. 1 agenda should be reducing unemployment. 'Make in India' has to be top priority"

-Ajay Sukumaran



SUMIT KUMAR

Fire in the Belly

Mayank Rathore dreamt of donning the olive green like his now-retired father, who served in the 14 Grenadiers regiment of the Indian army. The Rathores are farmers from a remote village in Nagaur district of Rajasthan. Despite his father's meagre income, Mayank studied at the Army School, Jaipur, as his father wanted him to get a good education. Preparing for the Agniveer exam, Mayank's day starts at 6 am with running and other physical exercises before heading to the coaching centre. He voted for the first time in the Rajasthan assembly election.

Mayank believes the Agniveer scheme does not do justice to youth who aspire to serve in the military. If one is not shortlisted after four years, his/ her career prospects are dim. Though Mayank is impressed by the Modi government's development work and its action against corruption, he feels the middle/ lower middle classes need more help. Mayank's younger brother, a class 8 student, also dreams of joining the army. "My father has been able to give me a good education and spent all his savings on it. But now he is retired. If I don't get settled in my career, he would feel bad. Joining the military has been my passion, but the Agniveer scheme restricts my chances," Mayank says. ■

- Pradip R. Sagar

MAYANK RATHORE, 18

Agniveer aspirant

Lok Sabha constituency: Nagaur, Rajasthan

Top 3 demands: Stronger military, checking corruption, tackling price rise

"Joining the military has been my passion. But the Agniveer scheme restricts my chances"